When the Mission Becomes a Trap: Missionary Dating, Spiritual Compromise, and the Biblical Responsibility to Leave an Abusive Relationship

"But become doers of the word, and not merely hearers who delude themselves." — James 1:22 (LSB)

The Great Commission calls Christians to make disciples and teach the nations to obey Jesus Christ (Matthew 28:18–20). That responsibility does not disappear when the person standing before us is someone we are attracted to. We ought to desire their salvation, share the gospel truthfully, and pray that the Lord opens their heart. But somewhere along the way, a good desire can become entangled with a dangerous decision. A Christian begins pursuing an unbeliever romantically and tells himself or herself that the relationship is an opportunity for evangelism. What may have begun as a sincere desire to point someone toward Christ becomes what many call missionary dating.

There are success stories. Some unbelieving men and women have encountered the gospel through someone they dated, believed in Jesus Christ, and eventually entered marriages marked by genuine faithfulness. We should never belittle those testimonies. God is merciful, and He can bring good from situations we would not have chosen. Yet a positive ending does not establish that every decision along the way was obedient or wise. The fact that the Lord can redeem a circumstance is not permission for us to disregard His Word in the hope that He will do the same thing for us.

The danger of missionary dating is not limited to entering a relationship with different beliefs. It is what can happen when the believer becomes emotionally attached, learns to make excuses for spiritual compromise, and stays long after the relationship begins destroying the very fellowship, peace, discernment, and obedience that should characterize the Christian life. A believer may begin with the intention of drawing another person closer to the Lord and discover, often gradually, that the relationship has pulled the believer further away from Him. Sometimes the situation goes beyond spiritual stagnation and becomes manipulative, controlling, or abusive. That is the circumstance we must be willing to confront.

An Unequal Yoke Is Not a Mission Field

Paul warns in 2 Corinthians 6:14–18 against being unequally yoked together with unbelievers. The immediate passage is not an instruction manual about modern dating, and we ought to handle Scripture honestly rather than pretending it explicitly describes a boyfriend and girlfriend. Nevertheless, Paul is addressing a real issue: the incompatibility of binding spiritual relationships that pull a believer toward loyalties contrary to Christ. That principle cannot simply be dismissed when considering a romantic relationship that is intended to lead to marriage.

A Christian who is serious about marriage is not merely looking for someone who is kind, attractive, entertaining, or emotionally available. Marriage joins two lives in a covenant with lasting responsibilities. It involves decisions about worship, truth, money, sexuality, forgiveness, ministry, and children. If one person recognizes Scripture as the authority for life and the other does not, that difference reaches into the foundation of the relationship. First Corinthians 7:39, although specifically addressing a widow who is free to remarry, says

that marriage should be only in the Lord. It would be unreasonable to ignore that direction while pursuing a relationship with marriage as its goal.

We should be equally clear about what these passages do not mean. An unbelieving person is not automatically cruel, abusive, or incapable of genuine affection. Nor does an unbeliever need to be avoided as a friend, neighbor, or person to whom we proclaim the gospel. Christ ate with sinners and called them to repentance. But friendship and evangelism are not the same as entering a romantic relationship. A Christian may be called to speak the gospel to someone without being called to date that person.

Some point to 1 Corinthians 7:12–16 or 1 Peter 3:1–2 as evidence that an unbelieving partner might be won through a believer's conduct. Those passages concern people already married. Paul does not tell a believer to abandon an existing marriage simply because a spouse is an unbeliever. Peter encourages wives to conduct themselves faithfully before husbands who disobey the Word. Neither passage commands an unmarried Christian to initiate missionary dating, and neither should be used to trap someone in an abusive dating relationship. The obligations of an existing marriage and the decision to begin a romantic relationship are not interchangeable.

When the Influence Begins to Reverse

Missionary dating is often defended by a simple expectation: "If I keep showing the love of Christ, this person will eventually change." But what happens when the person who intended to be a spiritual influence is the one who begins changing? Church attendance becomes less consistent. Friendships with mature Christians grow distant. Family members are treated as obstacles rather than people who care. Ministry, prayer, accountability, and time with other believers are repeatedly postponed because the relationship always seems to require one more sacrifice.

None of those circumstances by itself establishes abuse. People sometimes withdraw from others because of work, exhaustion, grief, ordinary relationship changes, or their own decisions. We need to examine the pattern and the reasons behind it. Yet when a romantic partner repeatedly discourages fellowship, resents time spent with trusted friends, punishes contact with family, or pressures the believer to choose between those relationships and the romance, the warning is no longer subtle. The partner's behavior is interfering with healthy support and potentially creating dependency.

The Christian may eventually recognize that something is wrong and say, "I need to grow closer to the Lord. I need godly friendships. I need to get back into fellowship." Those are good desires. But if nothing changes, we must ask whether the relationship has become an excuse for postponing obedience. A declaration of spiritual intention is not the same thing as pursuing it. Hebrews 10:24–25 calls believers to stir one another toward love and good works and not neglect gathering together. The Christian community is not an optional inconvenience that can always be sacrificed for the sake of keeping a romantic partner content.

This leads to a difficult question: who is influencing whom? We should not judge the answer by who possesses the Bible, who initiates an occasional prayer, or who identifies as the more religious partner. We should ask what direction the relationship is actually moving. Is the believer becoming more anchored in truth, more honest, more faithful, and more connected to the body of Christ? Or has the relationship become the center around which every conviction must be rearranged?

Bible Reading Is Not the Same as Bearing Fruit

Imagine the same couple begins reading Scripture every morning. This may be an encouraging beginning. God uses His Word to convict, correct, teach, and transform. We should welcome genuine interest in Scripture, including from someone who has not yet professed saving faith. But a morning devotional cannot be treated as decisive proof that the relationship has become spiritually healthy. If the rest of life remains unchanged, the Christian must not mistake the addition of one religious activity for a transformed direction.

James 1:22–25 describes the danger of hearing the Word without becoming a doer of it. Reading Scripture and walking away unchanged is compared to looking into a mirror and forgetting what one saw. The question is not simply whether the couple can recount what they read. The question is whether God's Word is being received with humility and obeyed. Is there greater truthfulness? Is manipulation being acknowledged and abandoned? Is there repentance after wrongdoing? Are healthy relationships being restored instead of further severed? Is the believer becoming more willing to obey Christ even when obedience is inconvenient?

Galatians 5:22–23 identifies the fruit of the Spirit as love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. These qualities are not manufactured through performance for another person. They develop through the Spirit's work in those who belong to Christ. Jesus also teaches that fruit reveals what is being produced in a life (Matthew 7:16–20). In its immediate setting, His warning concerns false prophets, so we should avoid treating every difficult relationship as though this passage gives us authority to pronounce someone's eternal destiny. Yet the broader biblical call to examine conduct rather than accept appearances remains necessary.

We must be careful not to confuse slow sanctification with the absence of salvation. Mature believers still struggle, repent, and sometimes fail. Likewise, a person newly encountering Christ may not yet demonstrate a long history of changed conduct. But when destructive conduct continues and the same promises are made repeatedly without corresponding action, the Christian is not required to ignore what is visible. We cannot see another person's heart, but we are responsible to respond wisely to the behavior we can observe. Hope should not require blindness.

Biblical Leadership Is Accountable to Christ

The responsibilities of Christian men and women also matter in this discussion, particularly when a dating relationship is presented as preparation for marriage. Ephesians 5:22–33 describes marriage with responsibilities for wives and husbands. Under a complementarian understanding of this passage, the wife recognizes her husband's headship, and the husband is called to love with the self-giving pattern of Christ. A man is not granted a license to control, belittle, isolate, or punish his wife. His responsibility is to love her, honor her, and exercise leadership accountable to the Lord. First Peter 3:7 likewise commands husbands to show honor to their wives as fellow heirs of the grace of life.

It is a serious matter for a Christian man to speak about leading a woman toward Christ. He should consider what his example is teaching her, what sacrifices he expects her to make, and whether his choices encourage holiness or compromise. One day, every person will answer to God for his or her own conduct; spiritual leadership cannot be used as a shield from that accountability (Romans 14:12). The man is not the savior of the woman, and he does not control her salvation. But he will answer for whether he acted with humility, truth, care, and obedience or used the language of leadership to serve himself.

A Christian woman is not called to passive silence in the face of sin. Proverbs 31 portrays a woman of wisdom, diligence, strength, and reverence for Yahweh. Priscilla and Aquila together instruct Apollos more accurately in Acts 18:26. A godly wife may encourage, counsel, challenge, and help her husband pursue Christ. She cannot manufacture his faith or carry his responsibility to repent. Equally, a man cannot demand that a woman follow his supposed spiritual leadership while he refuses to submit himself to God's Word.

There is another necessary distinction: dating is not marriage. The passages addressed to husbands and wives do not grant a boyfriend marital authority over a girlfriend. A woman who refuses an abusive boyfriend's demands is not thereby resisting biblical headship. A man who refuses a girlfriend's efforts to isolate him from family or church is not abandoning his responsibility to love. Both remain accountable to Christ, and neither has a biblical claim to dominate the other.

When children are involved, the responsibility grows more serious. Ephesians 6:4 instructs fathers to raise their children in the discipline and instruction of the Lord, while Deuteronomy 6:6–7 describes the ordinary rhythms of teaching God's Word within family life. Parents demonstrate their values not only by what they tell their children, but also through how they respond to fear, conflict, humility, repentance, and the treatment of others. Protecting children from abuse and preserving safe relationships with them are responsibilities that do not disappear because the parents' romantic relationship ends.

Isolation: When the Relationship Becomes a Place of Control

In my earlier paper, Recognizing a Jezebelian Spirit, I described a situation in which a controlling spouse isolates her husband from his support network and discredits his friends and family to preserve control. That illustration addresses more than a disagreement over social plans. It exposes a recognizable strategy of manipulation: the fewer trusted voices a person hears, the easier it becomes to dominate the narrative and persuade the person that the controlling partner is the only reliable source of truth.

Isolation often does not begin with a blunt demand to cut off everyone. It may begin with repeated criticism of friends, accusations that family members dislike the relationship, guilt whenever the Christian attends church or meets with a mentor, and arguments timed to make fellowship feel impossible. Eventually, the believer may stop accepting invitations because every outing brings conflict. The partner need not explicitly forbid a friendship if maintaining that friendship repeatedly results in emotional punishment.

From a Christian perspective, this also has a spiritual dimension. Ecclesiastes 4:9–12 describes the benefit of companions who help one another when they fall. Proverbs 13:20 commends walking with wise people. The church is instructed to encourage, correct, restore, and bear one another's burdens. When a person becomes cut off from mature believers, they lose ordinary opportunities for perspective and accountability. A controlling partner may then occupy more and more of the space once held by Christian community.

Scripture teaches that believers face spiritual opposition. Ephesians 6:11–12 speaks of the devil's schemes and spiritual forces of wickedness. That reality should make Christians watchful, but it does not authorize us to pronounce a particular partner demonically inhabited based on isolation, immaturity, or an abusive pattern. Human decisions still carry responsibility. We need not identify a demon in order to identify coercion, deception, or cruelty. Such behavior is dangerous because of what it does, whatever spiritual explanations someone may propose.

Abuse is not limited to physical assault. Emotional abuse can include humiliation, intimidation, unpredictable punishment, or threats of abandonment used to enforce compliance. Psychological abuse may

include persistent distortion of events, denial of plainly observable facts, surveillance, or accusations intended to make the victim distrust their own judgment. Spiritual abuse occurs when Scripture, prayer, claims of divine authority, or the language of submission and forgiveness are weaponized to coerce obedience or silence legitimate concerns. Financial control, stalking, threats, and deliberate isolation may also be part of a wider pattern of coercive control.

These behaviors must be evaluated seriously without assuming that every disagreement or immature action amounts to abuse. The determining concern is not whether a partner ever disappoints us. It is whether there is a sustained pattern of coercion, intimidation, degradation, restriction, or fear. A Christian does not need to wait for a bruise to recognize that a relationship has become unsafe. Nor should a pastor, friend, or family member minimize a person's account simply because the abusive partner appears religious in public.

When Promises of Change Become a Reason to Stay

One of the most painful features of a harmful relationship is that the partner may periodically offer exactly what the Christian has been longing to see. They agree to read the Bible, pray, attend a service, or acknowledge a concern. The believer feels hope again. Perhaps this really is the turning point. Genuine repentance is possible, and grace should never be dismissed. But neither should a brief period of cooperation be confused with a sustained pattern of repentance and restored safety.

Second Corinthians 7:10–11 connects godly sorrow with repentance and observable earnestness. The point is not that every repentant person immediately becomes mature, nor that a victim must conduct a trial to measure someone else's salvation. The point is that biblical repentance means turning, not merely expressing regret until the crisis has passed. Confession is not the same as accountability. A promise to stop isolating someone is not the same as actually supporting restored friendships. A willingness to hold a Bible is not the same as surrendering conduct to its authority.

This is where missionary dating can become a trap. The Christian interprets every small concession as evidence that perseverance will produce salvation, while every new episode of harm is explained as another reason to show patience. Eventually, the believer may fear that leaving would be selfish, unloving, or even responsible for the partner's rejection of Christ. Those conclusions confuse evangelism with captivity. The gospel calls us to speak truth in love, not to surrender judgment, safety, and spiritual community to keep someone romantically attached to us.

An abuser may also use Christian language to make leaving feel sinful: "You must forgive me," "God hates separation," "A godly woman would submit," or "If you loved me like Jesus, you would stay." These claims distort biblical responsibilities. Forgiveness does not require immediate reconciliation. Trust is not owed without regard to conduct. Submission is not permission for domination. And an unmarried person is not bound to maintain a dating relationship as though it were a marriage covenant.

Knowing When to Walk Away

The question is not whether someone has made enough spiritual progress to deserve another chance. Where abuse is present, the first concern is safety. A Christian in an abusive dating relationship may leave without waiting for visible spiritual fruit, one more confession, or permission from the abusive partner. Seeking protection is not a failure of evangelism. God has not appointed any believer to function as another person's redeemer. Jesus Christ is the Savior; that responsibility is His alone.

A believer who recognizes serious controlling behavior should seek counsel from trustworthy people who will prioritize safety and tell the truth: mature friends, family members where safe, qualified pastoral support, and professionals experienced in abuse. If leaving may provoke retaliation, the wisest first step may be a discreet safety plan rather than a confrontation. This may involve considering safe housing, transportation, passwords and device access, important documents, and the needs of children. Immediate threats warrant emergency assistance. Those precautions are not evidence of weak faith. They are examples of taking danger seriously.

It is also important not to offer one universal instruction for every household. Ending an unmarried dating relationship is distinct from navigating a marriage, a shared lease, joint finances, or child-custody obligations. Existing marriages require careful biblical and practical consideration; none of those complexities, however, should be used to deny a person the right to get to safety. And where children are involved, a parent's duty to protect and care for them persists even when the adult relationship ends.

Some may ask whether the Christian is abandoning someone who still needs the gospel. The answer is no. We can pray for someone from a distance. We can desire repentance without supplying access to ourselves. We can forgive without volunteering for further mistreatment. We can entrust the person to God and to appropriate sources of help. Our obedience is measured by faithfulness to Christ, not by whether another person accepts salvation on our preferred timeline.

What if the other person later changes? We should rejoice whenever God brings genuine repentance and spiritual growth. Yet later change does not retroactively make abuse acceptable, and it does not obligate the person who left to resume a romantic relationship. The decision to reconcile, where appropriate, is separate from the decision to forgive. A person's safety, freedom, and boundaries must not be surrendered to prove that forgiveness is sincere.

Guard Your Heart, and Do Not Lose Sight of Christ

Proverbs 4:23 calls us to guard the heart diligently because life flows from it. That is not an invitation to become cold or suspicious of everyone who has not yet believed. It is a call to exercise discernment over the influences we welcome into the most intimate places of our lives. Christians should proclaim the gospel freely and love people sincerely. But we must not permit romantic desire to transform evangelism into an excuse for abandoning what we know to be true.

Before entering a relationship, examine the foundation rather than merely the possibility. Is this person pursuing Christ, or am I hoping my affection will become the instrument that makes them pursue Him? Are we building toward a covenant grounded in the same Lord, or am I expecting emotional attachment to overcome spiritual division? What counsel am I willing to hear from believers who know me well? If the people who once sharpened me are becoming strangers, why?

And if a relationship is already harmful, ask the harder questions. Does it make room for truth, accountability, repentance, and healthy fellowship? Are disagreements handled without intimidation? Are promises accompanied by meaningful change? Am I staying because I see a safe and faithful relationship, or because I am afraid of what will happen if I finally walk away? When coercion and abuse are present, those questions should lead toward protection, not toward an endless demand for more patience.

A successful testimony may come from missionary dating. That reality deserves acknowledgment. But the possibility of a successful testimony is not a command to gamble with spiritual discernment or remain in an abusive relationship. A Christian may be a witness to someone without dating them. A Christian may love

someone without yielding to control. A Christian may pray for repentance without taking responsibility for producing it.

The mission was never to keep a relationship alive at any cost. The mission is to follow Jesus Christ. When the relationship begins demanding the very loyalty that belongs to Him, the Christian must be willing to choose obedience over attachment. And when a relationship becomes abusive, leaving is not proof that love has failed. It may be the clearest recognition that love and faithfulness do not require surrendering oneself to harm.

The One who saves is Christ. The One we follow is Christ. And the One whose Word must govern our steps is Christ—not the person we hoped to change.

All biblical references use the Legacy Standard Bible (LSB). The discussion of isolation also draws on Faith Based Pilot's "Recognizing a Jezebelian Spirit."